“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Antya-līlā

Chapter 17

The Tortoise Form in Ecstasy, and the Ravings of Madness

(English translation from the Bengali, following the Gauḍīya Maṭha edition and the «Anubhāṣya», 2026 — draft)

1 From the lips of those who saw them with their own eyes I have heard of the most wonderful, unearthly deeds of Śrīla Gauracandra in His divine madness, and now I describe them.[1]

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra, and glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

3 In this way, night and day, Mahāprabhu, absorbed in love, behaved like one mad and spoke in ravings.

4 One day the Lord passed half the night with Svarūpa and Rāmānanda, delighting in talks about Kṛṣṇa.

5 Whatever feeling arose in the Lord, Svarūpa Mahāśaya would sing a song to suit it.

6 And Rāya Rāmānanda would recite verses suited to His feelings from Vidyāpati, Caṇḍīdāsa and the *Śrī Gīta-govinda*.

7 Now and then the Lord would Himself recite a verse and, lamenting, explain its meaning.

8 So, amid many feelings, half the night went by. Then the two put the Lord to bed and went home.

9 Govinda lay down to sleep at the door of the Gambhīrā, and at midnight the Lord began to chant the holy names aloud.

10 Suddenly the Lord heard the song of Kṛṣṇa's flute and, absorbed in feeling, set off towards it.

11 The three doors stayed shut as they were, yet the Lord, lost in that feeling, passed outside.

12 To the south of the Siṁha-dvāra there was a herd of cows from Tailaṅga. The Lord went there and fell down unconscious.

13 Meanwhile Govinda, no longer hearing any sound from Mahāprabhu, opened the doors and called Svarūpa.

14 Then Svarūpa Gosāñi took the devotees with him, and they lit torches and went in search of the Lord.

15 After searching here and there, they went to the Siṁha-dvāra and found the Lord among the cows.

16 His hands and feet had drawn inside His body, and He had the shape of a tortoise. There was foam at His mouth, the hair of His body stood on end, and tears streamed from His eyes.

17 He lay unconscious, like a great pumpkin: outwardly inert, but within overwhelmed with bliss.

18 On every side the cows were sniffing the Lord's holy body; even when driven away, they would not leave His side.

19 The devotees tried hard to revive Him, but He did not regain consciousness. Then they lifted the Lord and carried Him home.

20 They sang the holy name loudly into His ears, and after a long while Mahāprabhu regained consciousness.[2]

21 As He came to Himself, His hands and feet emerged again, and His body returned to its proper form, as before.

22 The Lord sat up and looked about Him. He said to Svarūpa, "Where have you brought Me?

23 Hearing the sound of the flute, I went to Vṛndāvana, and I saw the son of the king of Vraja playing His flute in the pasture.

24 At the signal call of His flute Rādhā went to the bower, and Kṛṣṇa too went there for His pastimes.

25 I followed close behind Him, and the jingling of His ornaments captivated My ears.

26 Kṛṣṇa was enjoying His pastimes with the *gopīs*, laughing and jesting, and My ears rejoiced to hear His voice and His words.

27 Just then all of you raised an uproar and brought Me here by force.

28 I could no longer hear those words, sweet as nectar; I could no longer hear the jingling of His ornaments and the sound of His flute."

29 Absorbed in feeling, the Lord said to Svarūpa in a choked voice, “My ears are dying of thirst. Recite something full of the nectar of *rasa* — let Me hear it.”

30 Svarūpa Gosāñi, knowing the Lord’s mood, sweetly recited a verse from the *Bhāgavata*:

31 “O Kṛṣṇa, what woman in the three worlds, enchanted by the song of Your flute with its sweet, nectarean notes, would not stray from the conduct of the noble? Seeing this form of Yours, the beauty of the three worlds, even cows, birds, trees and deer bristle with rapture.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.29.40)[3]

32 Hearing this, the Lord became absorbed in the mood of the *gopīs* and began to explain the meaning of the verse:

33 Immersed in that mood, He entered the *rāsa* dance. There He heard Kṛṣṇa, smiling, speak words of indifference, and, taking them for a true rejection, He reproached Kṛṣṇa in anger:[4]

34 “O Beloved, tell us truly: of all the worthy women who fill the three worlds, which is not drawn by Your flute?

35 You sent the sound of Your flute into the world, and like a *yoginī* perfect in her mantras, it becomes a go-between and enchants the minds of women. It swells their longing, makes them forsake the path of the noble, and delivers them to You.

36 With Your flute You make us abandon *dharma*; You strike us with the arrows of Kāma, Your sidelong glances, and make us cast off shame and fear and everything else. And now You are angry with us, You say it is wrong to leave our husbands, and, like a man of virtue, You teach us *dharma*![5]

37 Your words say one thing, Your mind another, and outwardly You act in yet another way — all these are the artifices of a cheat. For You it is a jest, but for women it is utter ruin. Give up all these tricks!

38 The sound of Your flute outdoes nectar; Your sweet words are like nectar, and the jingling of Your ornaments is like nectar too. With these three nectars You steal our ears, You steal our minds, You steal our very life. How can a woman keep hold of her heart?"[6]

39 Having said this in anger, He floated on the waves of feeling, and His mind sank into an ocean of longing. Then He recited the words of Rādhā in Her yearning and, explaining them Himself, tasted the sweetness of Kṛṣṇa:

40 "O friend, His voice is like the rumbling of a thundercloud; the lovely jingling of His ornaments draws the ear; in the artful turns of His speech every syllable, word and meaning is playful and hints at *rasa*; and the soft note of His flute steals the hearts of Lakṣmī and other lovely women. That Madana-mohana of Mine deepens the longing of My ears." (Govinda-līlāmṛta, 8.5)

41 "The deep sound of His voice conquers the rumbling of a new cloud, and its sweetness puts the cuckoo to shame. Even a single drop of it, entering the ear, drowns the ears of the world, and those ears never come back again.[7]

42 Tell Me, O friend, what shall I do? The charms of that sound of Kṛṣṇa's stole My ears, and now, deprived of it, they are dying of thirst.

43 The sound of the bells on His ankles and waist conquers the cries of swans and cranes, and the jingling of His bracelets puts the *caṭaka* birds to shame. Once anyone hears it, it fills his ears and stays there, and no other sound can enter them again.[8]

44 The words of His holy mouth are a nectar higher than nectar, and the camphor of His smile is mixed into them. Their two powers, sound and meaning, bring out every kind of *rasa*, and every syllable is adorned with jest.[9]

45 One drop of that nectar is the very life of the *cakora* bird of the ears, and on the hope of it alone that *cakora* lives. Sometimes, by good fortune, it gets that drop; sometimes, by ill fortune, it goes without, and then it dies of thirst.

46 Let the women of the world hear but once the sweet sound of His flute, and their hearts are thrown into turmoil. The knots of their sashes slip loose; they become His unbought maidservants and, as if crazed, run to Kṛṣṇa's side.

47 Even the goddess Lakṣmī, hearing that soft song, comes to Kṛṣṇa in hope. But she does not obtain Kṛṣṇa's company; the waves of her thirst only swell, and though she performs austerities, she still does not attain Him.

48 Only one whose fortune is great drinks these four nectars of sound with his ears. As for one who does not hear them — why were such ears ever born? They are no better than a cracked cowrie shell."[10]

49 As He lamented in this way, agitation and other feelings arose in Him, and His mind had nothing to hold on to. Agitation, despondency, resolve, eagerness, fear, steadiness and remembrance — so many feelings came together in Him at once.[11]

50 Rādhā's words, spoken in such a mixture of feelings, had been revealed to Līlāśuka. In that same mood the Lord recited one of his verses and, by the power of His madness, drew out a meaning that people do not know:[12]

51 “What are we to do now? To whom can we speak? What was done in hope of Him is done. Speak of something else, something auspicious. Ah, but He lies in My heart! For Kṛṣṇa — the festival of mind and eyes, whose smiling form is sweeter than the sweetest — My wretched, most wretched thirst, alas, grows ever longer.” (Kṛṣṇa-karṇāmṛta, 42)[13]

52 “In this separation from Kṛṣṇa My mind is so agitated that it cannot be still, and I cannot think how to attain Him. And you, My friends — your minds too are crazed with despondency. Whom shall I ask? Who will tell Me the way?

53 Alas, alas, O friend, what shall I do? What can I do, where can I turn? Where must I go to find Kṛṣṇa? Without Kṛṣṇa My life is leaving Me.”

54 For a moment His mind became steady, and He reflected. But as soon as He began to speak, a new feeling arose: the remembrance of Piṅgalā’s words brought Him to a resolve, and in that mood He settled the meaning of the verse:[14]

55 “I see only this way: I will give up My hope for Kṛṣṇa. Once hope is gone, the mind is happy. Leave this inauspicious talk of Kṛṣṇa and speak of something else, something auspicious, so that I may forget Him.”

56 But even as She spoke, She remembered Him, and Kṛṣṇa appeared in Her heart. In astonishment She told Her friend, “He whom I want to forsake lies in My heart, and try as I may, I cannot let Him go.”[15]

57 Such is the wondrous nature of Rādhā’s feeling that it made Her see Kṛṣṇa as Kāmadeva, and at that thought Her heart was seized with fear. She said, “He who strikes down the whole world has entered My heart. This enemy will not let Me forget Him.”[16]

58 Then eagerness, conquering the armies of all the other feelings, rose to supremacy in its own kingdom, Her mind. Craving seized that mind, and, no longer mistress of Herself, She reproached it in sorrow:

59 “My mind is wayward and wretched. Like a fish without water, without Kṛṣṇa it dies in an instant. And Kṛṣṇa’s sweetly smiling face, the elixir of mind and eyes, makes My thirst for Him twice as great.[17]

60 Alas, Kṛṣṇa, treasure of My life! Alas, lotus-eyed one! Alas, divine ocean of virtues! Alas, Śyāmasundara! Alas, You who wear yellow cloth! Alas, Beloved, playful hero of the *rāsa* dance!

61 Where must I go to find You? Tell Me, and I will go there!” Saying this, the Lord ran off. But Svarūpa rose, caught Him in his arms, brought Him back and seated Him in His own place.

62 In a moment the Lord came back to outer consciousness and said to Svarūpa, “Svarūpa, sing something sweet.” Svarūpa sang songs of Vidyāpati and of the *Gīta-govinda*, and the songs soothed the Lord’s ears.

63 In this way, every night and day, Mahāprabhu behaved like one mad and spoke in ravings.

64 Even if one with a thousand mouths were to describe all the transformations of feeling that arose in Him in a single day, he could not reach their end.[18]

65 What can a lowly *jīva* like me describe of it? As one shows the moon by pointing to a branch, I give only an indication.

66 Whoever hears this finds his mind and ears soothed and comes to know the unearthly workings of hidden love.

67 The Lord Himself tasted the wondrous sweetness of that most secret love in all its glory, and showed its utmost limit.

68 Caitanya is wonderfully merciful, wonderfully generous! We have never heard of another giver in this world so merciful.

69 O people, worship the feet of Caitanya with all your heart! From them you will receive a treasure — the nectar of love for Kṛṣṇa.

70 Thus I have told how the Lord, in ecstasy, took the form of a tortoise, how He acted in His divine madness, and what ravings He uttered.[19]

71 Raghunātha dāsa has described this pastime in his own book, the *Caitanya-stava-kalpavṛkṣa*:

72 “Ah! Without opening the three doors, He passed high over the three tall walls and fell among the cows of Kaliṅga. Through His great separation from Kṛṣṇa His body contracted, and He appeared like a tortoise. That Gaurāṅga, rising in my heart, makes me mad with joy.” (Caitanya-stava-kalpavṛkṣa, 5)[20]

73 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.

Notes

1. *Anubhāṣya*: those who saw it were the most fortunate intimate devotees headed by Dāmodara and Raghunātha; “wonderful” — such as had never been heard of, “unearthly” — such as had never been seen. Heading in the edition: the transcendental pastimes of Gaura, heard from the lips of the guru by the path of *śrauta* (hearing). ↩
2. Heading in the edition: by the loud *saṅkīrtana* the Lord regains consciousness — a half-outward consciousness (*ardha-bāhya*). ↩

3. The same verse as Madhya 24.52; translation as there. The *Anubhāṣya* refers to Madhya 24.52. Heading in the edition: the sweetness of Kṛṣṇa's flute enchants and draws all His servants, whatever they may be. ↩
4. Heading in the edition: a gopī describes her feelings for Kṛṣṇa (*citra-jalpa*). *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: in the *rāsa-līlā* the gopīs heard Kṛṣṇa's indifferent words and took it as true that He had rejected them. ↩
5. Heading in the edition: "The transcendental young Madana, or Kāmadeva Anaṅga." ↩
6. *Anubhāṣya*: *ghole* — from the colloquial *ghola khāoyāya*, "makes [it] drink buttermilk", that is, outdoes, overpowers nectar. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya* understands it otherwise: the sound of the flute is nectarean buttermilk. In other editions (variant readings noted in the *Anubhāṣya*) — *role*, "with the sound", and *ugāre*, "pours forth". ↩
7. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the "ears" of the world are the other sounds of the world — once the least particle of this sound enters the ear, it so drowns them that they never come back. ↩
8. The *caṭaka* is a small chirping bird, the sparrow — not the *cātaka* that drinks only the rain (Antya 15.65). *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the *caṭaka* is a particular bird. ↩
9. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the two powers are the power of sound (*śabda-śakti*) and the power of meaning (*artha-śakti*); the words bring out the various rasas, beginning with *śṛṅgāra*. ↩
10. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the four nectars of sound are Kṛṣṇa's words, the jingling of His ankle-bells and bracelets, His voice and the sound of His flute. ↩
11. Heading in the edition: the mingling of feelings (*bhāva-śābalya*) in the Lord. ↩
12. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: Līlāśuka is Bilvamaṅgala Gosvāmī (Bilvamaṅgala Ṭhākura). In other editions (as noted in the *Anubhāṣya*) — "Līlāsukha". ↩
13. *Anubhāṣya*: "we" — Rādhā and Her friends, for they are in the same plight; the one lying in the heart is the enemy Kāma, who cannot be driven out and who is killing Her; the thirst is "wretched, most wretched", that is, faint with longing. ↩
14. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: Piṅgalā said, "Hope is the greatest misery; giving up hope is the greatest happiness" (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.8.44). *Anubhāṣya*: for the story of Piṅgalā see Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.8.22–44, and the *Mahābhārata*, *Śānti-parva* (*Mokṣa-dharma-parva*), ch. 174. ↩

15. Heading in the edition: Kṛṣṇa, as the transcendental Kāmadeva, takes possession of the heart. ↩
16. *Anubhāṣya*: *māre* — that is, “Māra”: He conquers the world as Kāmadeva. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: it makes Her see Kṛṣṇa as Kandarpa. ↩
17. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: *vāma-dīna* — wretched through its waywardness (*vāmya*). ↩
18. *Anubhāṣya* (on 65): even Ananta-deva, of boundless power, cannot describe with a thousand mouths the pastimes of Śrī Gaurāṅga in divine madness. ↩
19. Heading in the edition: the divine madness of the Lord described — *udghūrṇā* and *citra-jalpa*. ↩
20. *Anubhāṣya*: the three doors were in the house of Kāśī Miśra; “the cows of Kaliṅga” are the Tailaṅga cows — the capital of Tailaṅga, Kariṅga or Southern Kaliṅga, stood where the Godāvarī meets the sea, and a Tailaṅga cow is called in Sanskrit *kāliṅgika-surabhi*. Heading in the edition: the *Stavāvalī*, *Caitanya-stava-kalpavṛkṣa*, verse 5. ↩